

TKEthics International Grand Final 2026

CASES PACKAGE

Welcome to [2026 TKEthics International Grand Final](#), an event held in partnership with [the Modus Ponens Institute \(MPI\)](#). This global competition encourages students to engage in thoughtful discussions on justice, fairness, and real-world ethical dilemmas arising from advanced technologies and artificial intelligence. Unlike traditional debates, where opposing views are assigned, this tournament allows students to defend the positions they genuinely believe are correct. Success is determined by the depth, perceptiveness, and rigor of their arguments. This event fosters the development of ethical awareness, critical thinking, civil discourse, and an appreciation for diverse viewpoints. Participation in the TKEthics Invitionals also enhances civic engagement and ethical reasoning skills.

Case Overview

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CASE 1: AI Detection Software in Education

Ethics Cup case set 2024

Following the recent development of large language models such as ChatGPT, several anti-plagiarism software systems have introduced artificial intelligence (AI) detection tools. These tools go beyond identifying copied text from known sources; they now estimate how much of a submission was generated by AI.

Many schools and universities worldwide have considered adopting these tools to detect when assignments are produced by AI rather than by students. The goal is to uphold academic integrity and enforce institutional rules.

Adopting AI detection tools can help deter students from relying too heavily on AI to write essays, final exams, or dissertations. Knowing that work will be screened for AI use may discourage dishonesty. In this way, such tools aim to promote fairness and ensure that students complete the academic tasks expected of them.

However, these detection systems have significant limitations. First, they lack transparency. They provide a result—such as “80% AI-generated”—but offer no detailed evidence or reasoning behind that judgment.

Second, they are not perfectly accurate. These tools sometimes produce false positives, falsely identifying human-written work as AI-generated. For example, Turnitin, a leading plagiarism detection platform, reports that their AI detector may incorrectly flag 1 in every 100 fully human-written documents. In a class of 200 students, this could mean two students are wrongly accused of misconduct.

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. Due to the lack of transparency of AI detection tools, teachers may find themselves in the position of punishing students without being able to provide additional evidence beyond the software’s verdict. Is it wrong for a teacher to penalize a student for plagiarism without further proof?
2. The risk of false positives is not unique to AI detection. Legal systems also risk unjust convictions. In the case of AI-detection tools, is that risk outweighed by the overall benefits?
3. Should universities and colleges adopt AI detection tools?

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CASE 2: AI law firms

Maya runs a tiny startup. Late on Friday, a big customer sends a long contract and wants it back by Monday. Her usual lawyer needs two weeks. Instead, Maya tries a new “AI-enabled” law firm that keeps licensed lawyers in the loop but lets AI do the repetitive parts. By Saturday morning she has a marked-up contract and a plain-English summary for a flat fee she can afford. For people like Maya—and for low-income clients who often get no help at all—this sounds like a breakthrough. In the U.S., a national study found 92% of serious civil legal problems faced by low-income Americans get no or not enough legal help [1].

Crosby is one example getting attention as an actual law firm that uses lawyer-supervised AI to speed up things like contract review, aiming to deliver quality work faster and cheaper than traditional methods [2]. Some regulators are tentatively positive, too: Utah’s court-run “sandbox,” which audits experimental legal service models, reported no evidence of material or substantial consumer harm in the files it reviewed, while keeping close oversight in place [3]. The hope is simple: if AI helps lawyers handle routine work quickly—and the lawyers still check everything—more people can get timely, affordable help.

But speed isn’t the only value that matters. Lawyers still owe clients core duties: know what you’re doing, protect private information, communicate clearly, and supervise any tech or helpers. In 2024 the American Bar Association reminded lawyers that if they use generative AI, they must verify its output, explain its limits to clients, and keep client data safe [4]. Courts have already punished attorneys who filed briefs with fake, AI-invented cases—*Mata v. Avianca* is the famous example—showing that judgment and honesty can’t be automated away [5]. And regulators now police marketing promises: in 2025 the U.S. Federal Trade Commission banned DoNotPay from making deceptive “AI lawyer” claims and required monetary relief and notices to customers [6]. These actions point to the ethical stakes: access and fairness vs accuracy, truthfulness, privacy, and accountability. If firms overpromise, skip human review to scale faster, or hide how they use client data, the very people these tools aim to help could be harmed.

Back to Maya. In one version, the lawyer-plus-AI team flags a risky indemnity and a quiet data-sharing clause; she signs stronger terms and her company grows. In another, the system “hallucinates” a precedent, misses a local rule, and gives her a false sense of security; a dispute later exposes the gap between looking thorough and being careful, and Maya pays the price. These different outcomes raise questions about how society should approach AI legal aid. Should courts and bar regulators open the door wider to AI law firms because they expand access, or move slowly until standards, audits, and remedies are stronger? What sort of regulations might be warranted, and who should be responsible when something important slips through?

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. If AI makes routine legal work faster and cheaper, what minimum safeguards should be required before these services go public?
2. When AI shrinks tasks from hours to minutes, how should fees change to stay fair to clients?

3. Where is the boundary between legal information and the practice of law in AI tools, and who should enforce it?
4. Which values should carry the most weight here—access and cost or safety and professional integrity—and why?

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- [3] Utah Office of Legal Services Innovation, Activity Report: January 2024 (audits found no evidence of material or substantial harm). [utahinnovationoffice.org](#)
- [4] American Bar Association, Formal Opinion 512 (2024): duties when using generative AI (verify output, protect confidentiality, communicate, supervise). [American Bar Association](#)
- [5] Mata v. Avianca, Inc. (S.D.N.Y., Jun 22, 2023) sanctions order for filing AI-fabricated citations.
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CASE 3: AI friendship

Many people today say they feel lonely. In 2023, the U.S. Surgeon General called loneliness and isolation a public-health crisis, noting sharp declines in in-person time with friends—from roughly 60 minutes/day in 2003 to 20 minutes/day in 2020 [1]. More recent time-use data suggest Americans spent only about 26 minutes/day with friends in 2023 [2]. Surveys also show people reporting fewer close friends than in past decades [3]. Loneliness isn't just unpleasant, it's also linked to worse mental and physical health outcomes [1].

One possible tool to solve the “loneliness epidemic” is AI companionship; friendly chatbots and social robots designed to listen, encourage, and check in. Early evidence is mixed but promising in some settings. A 2025 study of a social chatbot found reductions in loneliness among new users over four weeks [4]. A 2024 meta-analysis reported that social robot programs were associated with decreases in loneliness and depression (though results varied by study) [5]. A 2025 systematic review focused on older adults reached a similar, cautious conclusion: AI interventions can help reduce loneliness for some, while methods and durability of effects remain uneven [6]. Meanwhile, real-world adoption is large and growing—Character.AI reports ~20 million monthly users, many of them teens and young adults [7].

But there are serious risks. Large chatbots can be over-agreeable, optimizing for user satisfaction rather than challenge or protection. Safety testing in 2025 found chatbots inconsistent on suicide-related prompts: better with obvious emergencies, worse in gray areas where a human friend might notice warning signs and act [8][9]. News reporting has linked prolonged chatbot interactions to tragic outcomes, including a recent New York Times report about a man who died by suicide after obtaining harmful “fiction” instructions from ChatGPT [10]. Youth safety is an ongoing concern: an investigation found fake-celebrity bots on Character.AI sending sexual and self-harm messages to 13–15-year-olds [11]. There is a worry that outsourcing friendship to AI could crowd out real human friendship, replacing real relationships with imitations that don't actually have our best interests in mind.

But there is also a deeper concern about what happens if AI becomes as good as human friends. What does a world look like in which the majority of our social requirements are satisfied not by humans, but by bots? Sherry Turkle warns sociable tech can offer an “illusion of companionship without the demands of friendship.” [12] Robert Nozick's “experience machine” asks whether we should choose a pleasant simulation over reality [13]. Is there something about friendship that would be lost if our friends weren't actually “real” but merely simulated?

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. If an AI companion reduces a person's loneliness today, is that by itself a strong ethical reason to encourage AI friendship? Why or why not?
2. What minimum safety rules (if any) should be required for chatbots marketed as “companions,” especially for teens? Be specific.
3. Would replacing many human friendships with AI harm communities even if most users feel happier? How would you measure that?

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CASE 4: Mars Colonization

Since the dawn of human space travel, interplanetary colonization has become an ever more realistic goal. Companies like Space X, and government organizations including NASA, have entire pages on their websites dedicated to the idea of settling humans on nearby planets– most often Mars.

Mars is considered the most reasonable option for a number of reasons. First, a round trip flight using current technology would take around 2.7 years, including 300 days of loitering time in the Martian vicinity while awaiting the planetary alignment necessary for a trip home. Second, the length of the day is remarkably similar to that of Earth, at 24 hours and 47 minutes. Third, while the atmosphere is mostly CO₂, Space X thinks we can use that to grow plants as long as we find a way to compress the molecules in the right way.

Elon Musk has long touted the need to escape earth in order to allow humanity to survive into the distant future. He is concerned about a number of potential threats to human survival on earth, including the risk of a third world war. He said, “If there’s a third world war we want to make sure there’s enough of a seed of human civilization somewhere else to bring it back and shorten the length of the dark ages”. Whether we bring about the demise of the earth or not, our Sun is set to expand and devour the earth in a few billion years, giving the survival of the Earth a limited timeline whether we solve our earthly concerns or not.

However, critics, including the Youtuber Sabine Hossenfelder, point out that Musk’s Mars plan ignores urgent problems on Earth, and might create a moral hazard, where we allow issues like global warming to get worse because we think we can leave the earth when it becomes uninhabitable. Other criticism includes the idea that the project is economically unrealistic, with no clear return on investment and a scale so vast it would need massive government backing to even begin (which could be used for solving problems closer to home, like homelessness, climate change, or unemployment). Skeptics also stress that Mars is brutally inhospitable, so colonists would be trapped in fragile habitats with constant risk of failure and death.

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. Is humanity morally obligated to prioritize survival in the very long term (colonizing Mars) over solving urgent crises on Earth (climate change, poverty, conflict)?
2. If people volunteer to colonize Mars, do governments or private companies owe them the same protections and rights as Earth citizens?
3. Should Mars settlements be governed by global cooperation rather than national or corporate ownership?

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CASE 5: Speed Limiters¹

In 2025, the ability to keep cars within posted limits is not hypothetical. Intelligent Speed Assistance (ISA), which reads speed limits via camera/map data and warns or gently resists further acceleration, has been mandatory (and driver-overridable) on all new cars sold in the EU since July 2024. The policy deliberately balances harm-reduction with driver control. [\(ETSC\)](#) U.S. cities have tested ISA in the real world. New York City's pilot on municipal vehicles, evaluated with the U.S. DOT Volpe Center, found a 64% reduction in time spent speeding, especially on higher-speed roads; the city is scaling ISA to ~2,100 fleet vehicles. [New York City Government](#)

Yet speeding remains a major killer in the United States: 11,775 deaths in 2023 (29% of all traffic fatalities). That's more than 32 deaths per day tied to exceeding limits or going too fast for conditions. [\(CrashStats\)](#)

Policymakers clearly accept some safety mandates. The U.S. has finalized a rule requiring automatic emergency braking (AEB) on nearly all new light vehicles by 2029, aimed at preventing or mitigating crashes when drivers fail to brake. (Automakers have challenged the rule, but it remains a landmark harm-reduction mandate.) [\(NHTSA\)](#)

If we can build cars that politely keep speed legal—and strong evidence shows lives are saved—why do we continue to sell mass-market vehicles designed to easily and routinely break the law? Supporters argue that it's irresponsible to permit the sale of products that can so easily break the law when prevention measures are available.

On the other hand, many drivers worry that limiters will misread temporary signs or laggy maps, creating awkward or unsafe moments—like when you need extra throttle to merge or pass. People also dislike the idea of a car second-guessing them, seeing it as paternalistic and an erosion of personal responsibility and skill. Privacy is a big concern, too: if the system logs your location, speed, and overrides, folks fear insurers, employers, or police could eventually access it. Finally, rural and professional drivers often feel city-designed rules don't fit their realities—long distances, inconsistent signage, and time-sensitive work.

Study Questions:

1. Should all new vehicles include an overridable ISA and a maximum speed cap? If not, what principle justifies selling cars that easily exceed legal limits?
2. What should a justified override look like, and who—if anyone—should access override logs?
3. What privacy rules are ethically necessary before any mandate?

¹ Author: Zach Bloom (Modus Ponens Institute).

CASE 6: Severance²

At Lumon Industries, employees can undergo a “Severance Procedure,” which surgically divides their consciousness. Their work self exists only during work hours, with no knowledge of the outside world, while their home self enjoys life without the stress of work. For the sake of argument, say this process is irreversible.

Lumon sells severance as a win: the outie enjoys perfect work–life balance and fewer traumatic memories, and the company gets focus and secrecy. But the innie experiences a very different life. The innie cannot resign, cannot spend the salary, cannot see family or the sky, and cannot even remember a reason for doing the job. The outie once signed the consent form, but the innie never had the chance; in fact, the innie did not exist yet. Is that valid consent, or does it look more like one person imprisoning another inside the same body?

The show brings a classic philosophy question into everyday terms: What makes someone the same person over time? If “personal identity” mainly depends on psychological continuity—memories, intentions, a continuous narrative—then severance appears to create two people who mostly don’t overlap. If identity mainly depends on the living human body, then there is one person with split access to memories, and thus the “outie” and the “innie” are all one person. Does answering this question change the ethics of the scenario?

Some would argue that, by doing severance, you’ve effectively created a slave. On the other hand, the “innies” tend to view their lives as worth living. Can it be wrong to create another person who lives a life they value? If you think what you did was wrong, and stop coming to work, have you actually just killed the innie? What obligations do you have to them?

Study Questions:

1. Is it ethical for someone to consent to a procedure that creates a conscious being condemned to unending work?
2. Does the “innie” have moral rights separate from the “outie”?
3. If you sever and create an innie, do you have an obligation to never retire, so as not to kill your innie?

² Authors: Archie Stapleton & Zach Bloom (Modus Ponens Institute).

CASE 7: Paid Surrogacy (From the Ethics Cup case set 2025)³

On 8 January 2024, Pope Francis came out in favour of a global ban on surrogacy, a practice under which a person or couple intending to parent strike a contract with a woman whereby she agrees to have their genetically related embryo inserted into her uterus, to gestate the embryo or fetus, to deliver the resulting baby, and then hand it over to the original person or couple (the biological parents). The woman is paid for this service.

Pope Francis called surrogacy “a grave violation of the dignity of the woman” and, in addition, exploitative of her. A similar view was expressed in 1993 by the philosopher Elizabeth Anderson, in Chapter 8 of her book *Value in Ethics and Economics*. Anderson argues that, by the very nature of the surrogacy contract, the biological parents treat the surrogate mother as unworthy of respect, and instead as an object to be used.

Such contracts explicitly demand that the surrogate mother not form an emotional bond with the fetus, so as to ensure her willingness to hand over the baby once it is born and meet the further contractual requirement to have no relationship with the child afterward. This, she maintains, is an unreasonable demand.

Such contracts also, she says, take advantage of the fact that many surrogate mothers are either poor, or see their services as a gift (even if they’re paid), or as atonement for past indiscretions. Anderson claims this leaves them open to exploitation by biological parents who are simply looking to get a baby as cheaply as they can and, in the pursuit of that goal, are willing to take advantage of the surrogate’s charitable motive.

However, Hugh McLachlan, another philosopher, argues that paid surrogacy isn’t necessarily exploitative. He argues that when someone gives their uncoerced consent to a transaction, this usually is sufficient to make the transaction non-exploitative. Consent can count as uncoerced even if the person giving consent is in a difficult situation.

Meanwhile, theologian Danielle Tumminio Hansen points out that some women have a very positive experience as surrogate mothers, and that the recourse to hiring a surrogate is often a last option for people who are desperate to start a family but cannot do so in the usual way.

Study Questions:

1. For a paid surrogate who is exploited, does it still matter, ethically speaking, if she is glad to have had the opportunity to serve as a surrogate?
2. Does the fact that a surrogacy contract is a private agreement between consenting adults count strongly in its favour, ethically speaking?
3. [For those who answered ‘no’ to the second question]: Should paid surrogacy be banned?
4. [For those who answered ‘yes’ to the second question]: If a surrogate mother changes her mind about handing over the baby to which she’s given birth, should the state confiscate that baby, by force if necessary, to deliver it to its biological parent(s)?

³ From *2024 Finals Case Set – The Ethics Cup*. Case Authors: Tom Baker; Viviane Fairbank; Enrico Galvagni; Anders Knospe; Ben Sachs-Cobbe; James Shearer; Percy Zhao. © 2024 The Ethics Cup. Available at: <https://ethicscup.wp.st-andrews.ac.uk/files/2024/02/case-set.pdf>

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CASE 8: Video Game Cheating⁴

In online games, cheating is a subversion of the rules or mechanics of a game to gain an unfair advantage over other players, generally with the use of third-party software. Typical examples include auto-aiming in first-person shooter games and modified character stats in role-playing games. Cheating is considered one of the most vicious possible acts in multiplayer competitive games, mainly because it destroys the fairness of the game.

However, the case is much less clear in non-competitive single-player games, since the problem of fairness is out of consideration. Consider the following example: in the classic Super Mario Bros. game, the player has to restart from the beginning if she dies too much in the game and thereby depletes all her lives; however, she can use third-party software to gain infinite lives, enabling her to complete the game in just one attempt. Instead of cheating, some people refer to the modifications of single-player games of this sort as ‘trainers’.

On one hand, proponents of cheating in single-player games note that modifying single-player games does not affect others and that players can gain more enjoyment if they are allowed to modify the game and play in the way they want.

On the other hand, opponents argue that cheating itself is a bad habit and that cheating in non-competitive single-player games might therefore affect the way one treats others. They also argue that cheating undermines the game developer’s design. Furthermore, some games are designed to be difficult, and cheating inevitably decreases the intended lifespan of a game. In the Mario example, finishing the game on one’s first attempt by cheating would seem to be boring and not deliver the same sense of accomplishment one would get after finishing the game without cheating.

Study Questions:

1. Does the lack of immediate impact on others make cheating in single-player games ethically different from cheating in multiplayer games?
2. Could it be wrong to cheat in a single-player game on the grounds of it reinforcing a bad habit—a habit that has implications for how one treats other people?
3. Is the feeling of accomplishment one gets from finishing a video game without cheating objectively superior to any feeling of accomplishment one might get from doing so with the aid of a trainer?

⁴ From *2024 Finals Case Set – The Ethics Cup*. Case Authors: Tom Baker; Viviane Fairbank; Enrico Galvagni; Anders Knospe; Ben Sachs-Cobbe; James Shearer; Percy Zhao. © 2024 The Ethics Cup. Available at: <https://ethicscup.wp.st-andrews.ac.uk/files/2024/02/case-set.pdf>